HAIR LOSS
05

Tretinoin

All-trans retinoic acid, a form of vitamin A acid, used on the skin



CLASS
Retinoid (vitamin A acid)

STUDIED FOR
Acne, fine wrinkles, hair loss

HUMAN EVIDENCE
Large trials; FDA approved

US STATUS
FDA approved (Retin-A, Renova)

STUDIED FOR

Acne	Fine facial wrinkles	Hair loss
HUMAN	HUMAN	HUMAN

Hair loss is off-label. A 2007 trial in 31 men found no significant difference between minoxidil alone and minoxidil plus tretinoin.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Tretinoin ▶ Follicle cells ▶ Faster turnover ▶ Comedones cleared

- **Exact mode of action** is unknown, per the label
- **Follicle-lining cells** stick together less and turn over faster
- This pushes out **blackheads and whiteheads** (comedones)
- **Raised minoxidil absorption** through the skin nearly threefold in 19 men

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Approved for acne since 1971
- 5 controlled wrinkle trials, 24 weeks
- Hair: 1 small study, 1 trial of 31 men

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Daily use beyond 52 weeks
- Long-term use for hair loss

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
Not established (not on the label)

ROUTES STUDIED
On the skin (cream, gel)

PHARMACOKINETICS
Under 2% absorbed through skin in 7 men (0.05% cream)

SOLD AS
Prescription cream and gel (Retin-A, Renova, generics)

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Skin irritation, sun sensitivity

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved for acne and fine wrinkles; not hair loss
FDA	Compounded hair sprays are not FDA approved
WADA	Not on the 2026 list

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Retin-A prescribing information (DailyMed), May 2024
2. FDA, Renova prescribing information (DailyMed), Feb 2026
3. Shin et al., Am J Clin Dermatol, minoxidil vs minoxidil plus tretinoin, 2007

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